

The Fuel Theory of Grudges:

Pseudo-Realistic Revenge Cinema, Paranoid Narrative Worlds, and the Psychological Cost of Endless Vigilance

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Abstract

This essay develops an informal but psychologically motivated framework for understanding long-term revenge narratives in modern commercial cinema. The central claim is simple: intense grudges require fuel. Human beings are not naturally designed to sustain maximum emotional hostility indefinitely. Yet many revenge films portray decade-long vendettas with mythic consistency and near-total emotional continuity. This essay argues that such stories often operate in a hybrid space between realism and mythology — appearing psychologically realistic on the surface while secretly relying on epic, paranoid, or hyper-symbolic logic underneath.

The paper introduces three related ideas: the “Fuel Theory of Grudges,” the notion of “pseudo-realistic cinema,” and what is termed the “John Nash Trap” — a narrative condition in which all relationships become suspect and reality itself appears transformed into an interconnected web of hidden enemies and engineered betrayal. The broader philosophical argument is that a world without trust becomes psychologically unlivable. Endless vigilance may preserve survival in fiction, but in ordinary life it risks dissolving the emotional foundations of human existence itself.

1. Introduction: The Exhaustion of Eternal Revenge

Modern revenge cinema often asks the audience to believe in a peculiar emotional miracle: that human beings can remain equally angry for ten years.

Not wounded for ten years. Not saddened for ten years. Not quietly resentful for ten years.

Angry.

Boiling hot.

Emotionally volcanic.

This emotional continuity is one of the hidden engines of commercial revenge storytelling. Entire cinematic universes are constructed upon grudges that refuse to decay. Characters wake up each morning with the same degree of rage they possessed years earlier, as if hatred were immune to time, routine, work, children, aging, or emotional exhaustion.

But real life rarely behaves this way.

Human beings forget. They become tired. They adapt. They get distracted. They fall in love again. They become parents. They get jobs. They lose energy. Sometimes they forgive. Sometimes they merely become numb.

Life introduces entropy into emotion.

This essay emerged from a simple dissatisfaction with a popular revenge narrative. The issue was not merely that the story felt unrealistic. Rather, it felt *psychologically over-engineered*. Characters behaved as though they inhabited a universe where emotional intensity never cooled, where conspiracies expanded infinitely, and where every relationship might secretly conceal another layer of betrayal.

The result was a strange sensation: the film looked realistic, but emotionally it behaved like mythology.

This essay attempts to understand that sensation.

2. The Fuel Theory of Grudges

The central thesis of this paper can be stated in one sentence:

Long-term intense grudges require fuel.

Hatred is not emotionally self-sustaining. It consumes psychological energy. To maintain severe anger over long periods of time, some reinforcing mechanism must continuously reactivate the emotional wound.

Several such mechanisms commonly exist.

2.1. Continuous Reinforcement

Some grudges survive because the injury never fully stops happening. A legal battle continues. A public humiliation is repeatedly revisited. Families continue fighting. Communities retell the story. Social media reopens the wound every few weeks.

In such cases, the grudge is periodically refueled.

Without reinforcement, however, even serious anger often begins to cool.

2.2. Identity Fusion

Sometimes the grudge ceases to be an emotion and becomes an identity.

The individual no longer merely says:

“I was wronged.”

Instead, the person becomes:

“The wronged one.”

The grievance becomes psychologically inseparable from selfhood. Losing the grudge would feel like losing one’s narrative purpose.

This helps explain why some cinematic characters appear emotionally frozen in time. Their hatred is no longer a temporary feeling; it has become their existential architecture.

2.3. Mythic Inheritance

In some stories, revenge becomes hereditary.

Children inherit the emotional wars of their parents. Families behave less like modern individuals and more like ancient dynasties carrying sacred blood feuds across generations.

At this point the grudge is no longer psychological realism. It becomes mythology.

3. Pseudo-Realistic Cinema

Many revenge films produce a curious cognitive illusion. They *look* realistic while behaving according to mythic emotional laws.

Characters:

- wear ordinary clothing,
- use smartphones,
- live in modern cities,
- speak colloquial language,
- have jobs and families,
- operate within recognizable social environments.

Yet emotionally they behave like epic warriors from ancient sagas.

This creates what may be called **pseudo-realistic cinema**.

The surface texture is contemporary realism. The underlying emotional logic is mythological absolutism.

This explains why certain films feel simultaneously immersive and psychologically strange. The audience subconsciously detects two incompatible systems operating at once.

3.1. The Triple Character Problem

In many franchise narratives, characters operate on three layers simultaneously:

1. **The Human Layer**

Ordinary emotional realism.

2. **The Franchise Layer**

Callbacks, continuity preservation, iconic rivalries, fan expectations.

3. **The Mythic Layer**

Destiny, blood-feud symbolism, operatic revenge, exaggerated moral drama.

These layers often fail to synchronize.

A character may behave realistically in one scene and then suddenly transform into a mythological archetype in the next. The audience experiences this as tonal instability or emotional overacting, even when the acting itself is competent.

The issue is not performance. The issue is narrative ontology.

4. The John Nash Trap

One of the most psychologically interesting features of paranoid revenge narratives is the collapse of trust.

The protagonist begins suspecting not merely enemies, but *systems*.

Relationships become weaponized. Friendships become suspect. Coincidences become strategic. Social interactions become surveillance mechanisms.

Reality itself transforms into an interconnected network of hidden intention.

This condition may be termed the **John Nash Trap**, named metaphorically after the famous mathematician portrayed in *A Beautiful Mind*. The reference here is not intended as clinical diagnosis but as narrative structure.

The trap works as follows:

Once every interaction becomes interpretable as hidden conspiracy, reality itself becomes psychologically unstable.

At this stage:

- strangers may secretly be agents,
- family friends may be infiltrators,
- ordinary events become coded signals,
- social life becomes impossible to relax into.

The world ceases to feel inhabited and begins to feel engineered.

4.1. The Infinite Enemy Problem

Many revenge thrillers escalate conflict by continuously expanding hidden connections.

The enemy's cousin knows another enemy. The police officer secretly works for another faction. The friend is compromised. The ally is spying. The servant belongs to another network. The betrayal has another betrayal behind it.

Narratively this creates suspense.

Psychologically it creates exhaustion.

Because in real life, human systems are usually too chaotic to sustain infinitely layered conspiracies. Real people forget things. They become lazy. They lose interest. They move on. Coordination collapses.

Reality contains entropy.

Paranoid narratives often remove entropy entirely.

5. A World Without Trust

The deeper philosophical concern behind this essay is not merely cinematic realism. It is existential.

What happens when trust itself collapses?

A human being can survive occasional danger. A human being can survive heartbreak. A human being can survive betrayal.

But can a human being meaningfully live in a universe where every relationship is potentially hostile?

At some point, endless vigilance becomes spiritually corrosive.

5.1. Psychological Death

There exists a form of existence that is biologically alive but psychologically unlivable.

A person trapped in permanent hypervigilance cannot truly rest. Every interaction must be analyzed. Every kindness becomes suspicious. Every coincidence appears strategic.

This is not life in the ordinary sense. It is defensive survival.

One begins to understand why many philosophical and religious traditions emphasize surrender, forgiveness, or faith. Not because danger is unreal, but because total suspicion destroys the emotional conditions required for human flourishing.

6. Forgiveness, Entropy, and Ordinary Life

Most real human beings eventually drift away from maximum emotional intensity.

The wound may remain. The memory may remain. The embarrassment may remain.

But the emotional temperature changes.

A failed relationship eventually becomes a story. A humiliation becomes an anecdote. A betrayal becomes a scar rather than an active battlefield.

This transition is not weakness. It is psychological adaptation.

Human life depends upon emotional entropy.

Without entropy, every injury would remain permanently fresh. Every embarrassment would remain permanently catastrophic. Every insult would remain eternally present.

Civilization itself would collapse under cumulative resentment.

7. Why Cinema Prefers Eternal Rage

Cinema, however, has different incentives.

Stories require continuity. Franchises require iconic rivalries. Audiences enjoy emotional intensity. Revenge produces dramatic propulsion.

Thus films often preserve emotions in artificial suspension.

Hatred remains chemically pure. Enemies remain symbolically central. The past never fully recedes.

In reality, most people are too exhausted for this.

The ordinary person must still:

- pay bills,
- raise children,
- go to work,
- recover from illness,
- maintain relationships,
- and continue living.

The human nervous system was not designed for endless cinematic escalation.

8. Conclusion: The Necessity of Trust

This essay has argued that many revenge narratives secretly depend upon psychologically unrealistic emotional continuity. Long-term hatred requires fuel. Without reinforcement, most emotions decay, transform, or become absorbed into ordinary life.

The essay also introduced the idea of pseudo-realistic cinema: narratives that visually imitate realism while emotionally operating according to mythic logic.

Finally, it proposed the “John Nash Trap” as a metaphor for paranoid narrative worlds in which every relationship becomes potentially weaponized and trust collapses entirely.

The broader philosophical conclusion is simple.

Human beings cannot meaningfully live under conditions of absolute suspicion.

Some caution is necessary. Some vigilance is necessary.

But eventually one must risk trust.

Otherwise existence becomes a prison of interpretation — a world in which every conversation conceals conspiracy, every relationship conceals betrayal, and every human interaction becomes another layer in an infinite architecture of fear.

At that point, survival itself begins to resemble a diminished form of death.

“A civilization survives not merely because people fear enemies, but because people still dare to trust one another.”